to become Springboks and global stars of the game.

More than 14 000 spectators occupied every available space around the A field and we started in a blur, scoring early, dominating every phase of the game. Our crowd was delighted, roaring approval of every move, every break and every tackle. Life could not get any better than this.

We led 21–0 towards the end of the first half; then we won a scrum on our 22-metre line. Heino Kühn whipped the ball back to me and I aimed to punt the ball into touch … but Ruan Pienaar managed to charge down my kick, collected and scampered clear to score a try. I have always insisted that Ruan was at least two metres offside – that's my story, and I'm sticking to it – but the referee awarded the try, our lead was reduced to 21–7 and, on the stroke of half-time, the tide had turned.

There is a Grey legend that Hansie telephoned his father Ewie during the break, relayed the score and said he thought Grey could still fight back and win the game.

So it proved. Grey mounted attack after attack. In one move, Bismarck du Plessis literally ran straight over me. Then they scored again. We called an intricate move deep inside our own half in which I was meant to dummy both centres before popping the ball inside to the wing, but only succeeded in being crunched by their inside centre, Rieel de Kock. They scored again. I think it's true to say I touched the ball three times in those last 20 minutes.

Final score: Affies 21, Grey College Bloemfontein 46.

Our only consolation was that, for the fifth year in succession, adding up the results of all the age-group matches played between the schools on the same day, we won more matches than Grey.

The following weekend, we travelled to play Maritzburg College in Pietermaritzburg and scored an outstanding try late in the game to secure a 20–19 win. However, the match – like every match played in South Africa on Saturday, 1 June 2002 – was overshadowed by the shocking news that Hansie Cronjé had died earlier that morning in an air crash in